

Reviews

Review 1

Brief Summary of Goals and Findings

The experiment uses the visual world paradigm to contribute to the discussion of whether the default exhaustive interpretation of preverbal focus construction sentences is inherent to the structure or due to pragmatic context. Authors describe results as supporting exhaustive interpretation being inherent to structure.

Research Objective

4 - Strongly motivated research question

Study Design

3 - Mostly appropriate, only minor concerns

Methods & Analysis

3 - Only minor concerns

Conclusions

3 - Mostly warranted

Impact/Innovation

3 - Potential for impact/innovation along a single dimension

Recommendation for Acceptance

4 - Definite Yes

Comments to the Authors

The question examined in the abstract seems to be relevant to the venue, and one that other researchers have focused on. I would incorporate the fact that the two potential conclusions for this study are not mutually exclusive.

As non-exhaustive interpretations are possible, the exhaustive interpretation is not an immutable part of the construction. As it does seem to be the default interpretation, it is possible that the frequent pragmatic context supporting this interpretation has strengthened this use-based default.

Review 2

Brief Summary of Goals and Findings

This abstract reports a visual-world eye-tracking study investigating the interpretation and processing of Hungarian pre-verbal focus (PVF) constructions, with particular attention to exhaustivity and contrast. The authors compare unmodified PVF sentences to explicitly exhaustive (csak 'only') and explicitly contrastive (többek között 'among others') constructions. Behavioral choice data show a strong exhaustive bias for unmodified PVFs, while contrastive sentences favor non-exhaustive interpretations. Eye-tracking measures reveal facilitation effects for explicitly exhaustive and contrastive conditions, but not for simple PVFs, suggesting online disambiguation of an underspecified structure. The results are argued to reconcile long-standing theoretical debates by showing that PVFs are biased toward exhaustivity in

interpretation, while remaining semantically underspecified during processing.

Research Objective

4 - Strongly motivated research question

Study Design

3 - Mostly appropriate, only minor concerns

Methods & Analysis

3 - Only minor concerns

Conclusions

2 - Only somewhat warranted

Impact/Innovation

3 - Potential for impact/innovation along a single dimension

Recommendation for Acceptance

3 - Weak Yes

Comments to the Authors

This abstract could benefit from a bit more clarity in the presentation of the results. Why were the SPR times collected? No results are reported for this dependent measure. Also, the fact that the authors did not include visualizations of the results makes the abstract particularly hard to follow. I am also confused about Table 2. How is there no difference in dwelling times in the simple PVF condition but there is a difference

in the contrastive condition given
the values reported in Table 2?

Review 3

Brief Summary of Goals and Findings

This abstract presents the results
of a visual world study
investigating the availability of a
exhaustive focus interpretation of
pre-verbal items in Hungarian (and
the extent to which contrastivity
intersects with the availability).

Research Objective

4 - Strongly motivated research
question

Study Design

3 - Mostly appropriate, only minor
concerns

Methods & Analysis

4 - No concerns

Conclusions

4 - Strongly warranted

Impact/Innovation

3 - Potential for impact/innovation
along a single dimension

Recommendation for Acceptance

4 - Definite Yes

Comments to the Authors

I think this is an excellent study
that strongly informs debates about

Hungarian focus, which has been highly influential in the linguistics literature on focus. The interpretation of the results seem sensible. I do wish that the mechanisms of focus interpretation had been included in more detail in the abstract, but I'm hoping this will play a more central role in the presentation!

Review 4

Brief Summary of Goals and Findings

This abstract presents the results of a combination SPR, scene verification and visual world eyetracking study examining the interpretations of different ways of marking focus in Hungarian: simple pre-verbal focus, PVF with 'only', and PVF with 'among others'.

The results suggested that the simple PVF and 'only' sentences were interpreted similarly. Some differences in latency and fixations further modulated the interpretation. In particular, the exhaustive reading with 'among others' persists, though it ultimately leads to a contrastive interpretation.

Research Objective

3 - Clear, grounded research question

Study Design

2 - Some concerns

Methods & Analysis

3 - Only minor concerns

Conclusions

3 - Mostly warranted

Impact/Innovation

2 - Potential for solid, incremental progress

Recommendation for Acceptance

4 - Definite Yes

Comments to the Authors

This experiment provided a large amount of data (SPR, scene choice, and fixations), much of which was not able to be squeezed into a single data page. It would be interesting to see more details of the results in order to interpret the implications for extant theories.

This is not a typical VWP design since the language is written, which means it does not allow close time-locking between linguistic input and interpretation. Partly because of this is is not clear what the underlying linking assumption is for "dwell time".

This seems potentially to be a good first experiment examining the interface among syntactic structure and semantic and pragmatic interpretations. It's typical for the less likely option to take longer to select (the B means for Exh and PVF) and even longer when the two options are competitors (A/B in Cont). I would say the latencies do not add much beyond the picture choice, but maybe I'm not understanding the linking theory (e.g. what exactly dwell time means).

Maybe this is clear from the abstract, but the fact that the Exh is somewhat slower (well 41 ms) could mean that there is a little bit of ambiguity there that's eliminated in the PVF condition (only 1.5%

though).

One small item: Why is the verb different in the fronted version?

I think this study will be of interest to some in the HSP community. I would like to see it presented, though with more detail about the different types of data provided, and clearer linking between the theoretical assumptions and the dependent variable(s).